

At OU, Sign-Ups Outpace Attendance as Students Rebuild Community

By Vani Ellis

Student organizations at the University of Oklahoma are seeing a growing gap between the number of students listed as members on OU Engage and the number who consistently show up, but leaders say involvement is shifting toward community rather than résumé building.

According to OU's Registered Student Organization policies, students become official members by joining through OU Engage, the university's platform for tracking involvement and managing rosters. But that official count doesn't always reflect who is actually participating.

Green Week Executive Chair Mikayla Riddle said her organization has 121 students listed on OU Engage, yet weekly meetings draw closer to 25 active members. "People are burnt out, or they're just trying to survive during the semester," Riddle said. She added that Green Week has adapted by posting reels, tabling more often and using the OU Snapchat story to reach freshmen who may not know how to find organizations.

The Korean Student Association sees the opposite pattern — more students show up in person than officially join. Officers said international students especially have been attending more consistently this year, often after meeting members during Howdy Week or seeing graphics on Instagram. "Our games are very welcoming and chill," one officer said. "People come for the food and activities, but they stay because they find a sense of community."

At the Union Programming Board, attendance varies widely depending on the event. Craft-based programs like Slime & Snacks draw around 30 students, while larger events such as Retro Night or Dancing with the Stars can reach 300–400 attendees.



OU students make slime and chat during the Union Programming Board's Slime & Snacks event on Wednesday afternoon.

Executive chair Emma Silma said she's noticed a shift in why students participate. "People are actively wanting to connect and be on campus," she said. "It's becoming less about résumé building and more about community."

This trend mirrors global patterns. A UNESCO report on post-COVID student life found that students worldwide have been slower to return to regular extracurricular involvement, often preferring flexible, one-time events over weekly commitments. Many reported burnout, social anxiety and difficulty reconnecting after years of online schooling.

UPB officer Monika Bolaneni said OU students show similar behavior. "The free things get people in the door," she said. "But the community is what gets people to stay."

Across organizations, leaders agree that involvement looks different than it did before the pandemic. Students may sign up for multiple orgs, attend only certain events or drop off during midterms and finals — but they're also showing a renewed desire for connection.

"I think engagement is at a really good high this year," Silma said. "People just want to be part of something."

Source List

Human Sources

1. Mikayla Riddle

Executive Chair, Green Week

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Interview conducted in person on March 25, 2026.

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Interview conducted in person on March 25, 2026.

3. Emma Silma

Executive Chair, Union Programming Board

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Interview conducted in person on March 26, 2026.

4. Monika Bolaneni

Chair of Daytime Programming, Union Programming Board

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Interview conducted in person on March 27, 2026.

Informational / Online Sources

5. University of Oklahoma Registered Student Organizations (RSO) Policies

University of Oklahoma. "Registered Student Organizations."

<https://www.ou.edu/rso>

Used to establish OU's official definition of membership and how OU Engage tracks involvement.

6. UNESCO – Post-COVID Student Engagement Trends

UNESCO. "Education: From disruption to recovery."

https://www.unesco.org/sites/default/files/education_in_a_post-covid_world-nine_ideas_for_public_action.pdf

Used to provide international context on declining extracurricular participation and post-pandemic student burnout.